coursera | MoMA

Modern Art & Ideas

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Modern Art & Ideas

Module 2
Places & Spaces

Module 3
Art & Identity

Module 4
Transforming Everyday Objects

Introduction to Transforming Everyday Objects
- Welcome to Module 4 — Reading • 10 min
- Transforming Everyday Objects — Video • 4 min

Transforming How Objects Look
- How do artists draw from their surroundings? — Reading • 20 min
- Ruth Asawa. Untitled (BMC. 145, BMC Laundry Stamp). c. 1948-49 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Noah Purifoy. Unknown. 1967 — Video • 2 min

Transforming What Objects Mean
- How do artists alter the meaning of objects? — Reading • 10 min
- Alfonso Ossorio. Empty Chair or The Last Colonial. 1969 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Diamond Stingily. Entryways. 2021 — Video • 1 min

Transforming What Objects Do
- How do designers problem-solve? — Reading • 10 min
- Clara Porset. Butaque Chair. 1957 — Video • 2 min
- Tomás Gabzdil Libertiny. The Honeycomb Vase "Made by Bees" (Prototype). 2006 — Video • 2 min

Review & Reflect
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Assessment:Transforming Everyday Objects — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection — Reading • 10 min

Module 5
Module 5: Art & Society

Introduction to Art & Society
- Welcome to Module 5 — Reading • 10 min
- Art & Society — Video • 4 min

Responding to Society
- How do artists and designers respond to social conditions? — Reading • 10 min
- Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Jacob Lawrence. Migration Series. 1940-41 — Video • 2 min

Challenging Society
- How do artists challenge social conditions? — Reading • 10 min
- Ernest Cole. Untitled. c. 1960 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Martha Rosler. House Beautiful (Bringing the War Home). 1967-72 — Video • 2 min

Shifting Perspectives
- How do artists and designers shift perspectives? — Reading • 10 min
- Hanes, Inc. White T-Shirt. 1910s — Video • 2 min
- Gilbert Baker. Rainbow Flag. 1978 — Video • 3 min

Review & Reflect
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Assessment: Art & Society — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection — Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Course Conclusion

How do artists and designers respond to social conditions?

0:04 / 7:10 1x



Ernst Ludwig Kirchner. *Street, Dresden*. 1908 (reworked 1919; dated on painting 1907). Oil on canvas, 59 1/4" x 6' 6 7/8" (150.5 x 200.4 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Purchase

At the time he made this painting, Ernst Ludwig Kirchner was living in Dresden, a large city in southeast Germany. In a letter to a fellow painter, he wrote, "Completely strange faces pop up as interesting points through the crowd. I am carried along with the current, lacking will. To move becomes an unacceptable effort." The crowded city street—here, Dresden's fashionable and wealthy Königstrasse (King Street)—was a frequent subject for artists in the German Expressionist collective Die Brücke (The Bridge), which Kirchner helped found in 1905. Artists associated with Die Brücke sought an authenticity of expression that its members felt had been lost with the innovations of modern life.

Kirchner heightened the colors of this city scene, depicting the figures with masklike faces and vacant eyes in order to capture the excitement and psychological alienation wrought by modernization. These urban dwellers appear isolated from each other even though they are densely packed together. A sense of alienation and anxiety imbue the artist's vision of modern urban bustle. "The more I mixed with people the more I felt my loneliness," he once said.









Grete Shütte Lihotzky. Frankfurt Kitchen from the Ginnheim-Höenblick Housing Estate, Frankfurt am Main, Germany. 1926–1927. Various materials, 8'9" x 12'10" x 6'10" (266.7 x 391.2 x 208.3 cm). Gift of Joan R. Brewster in memory of her Husband George W.W. Brewster, by exchange and the Architecture & Design Purchase Fund

In the late 1920s, approximately ten thousand kitchens designed by Grete Schütte-Lihotzky were at the core of a far-reaching program to modernize public housing and infrastructure in Frankfurt. Inflation and war had precipitated a housing crisis in all major German cities. Under the direction of chief city architect Ernst May, the so-called New Frankfurt became a testing ground for modern architectural forms, new materials, and innovative construction methods.

The Frankfurt Kitchen was designed like a laboratory or factory and in accordance with contemporary theories of efficiency, hygiene, and workflow. Schütte-Lihotzky's primary goal was to reduce the burden of women's labor in the home. In planning the design, she conducted detailed time-motion studies and interviews with housewives and women's groups. Each kitchen came with a revolving stool, a gas stove, built-in storage, a foldaway ironing board, an adjustable ceiling light, and a removable garbage drawer. Labeled aluminum storage bins were provided for staples like sugar and rice, and they were designed with spouts for easy pouring. Careful thought was given to the choice of materials: oak was used for flour containers (to repel mealworms) and beech for cutting surfaces (to resist staining and knife marks). The result is one of modernism's most famous cooking spaces.



Tim Ferguson Sauder, Brian Glenney, Sara Hendren. Accessible icon. 2009-2011. Digital image. Gift of the designers

The Accessible Icon Project redesigns the decades-old International Symbol of Access. Unlike the previous icon, in which the wheelchair user looks passive and ready to be pushed to a destination, the new one shows a person in forward motion—a "driver" in charge of their own fate. The designers introduced their version in a street-art campaign, printing it on stickers and pasting it over older accessibility signs in the Boston area.

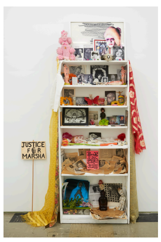
The redesign has now been officially adopted by some businesses and institutions, and even by such cities as Malden and Burlington, Massachusetts, and El Paso and Austin, Texas. New York City uses a modified version, with the figure hailing a cab, to denote its accessible taxis.



Chow & Lin. *The Poverty Line (Tomatoes) (The United States of America)*. 2010-2020. Inkjet print, each: 15 9/16 × 22 13/16" (39.5 × 58 cm). Gift of the Fund for the Twenty-first Century and Committee on Architecture and Design Funds

For the Beijing-based artist duo Chow and Lin, food has been a daily fascination. "We were both born with silver spoons," says Stefen Chow. "But before both of us were old enough for school, our families lost everything. Both of our fathers were bankrupt." This experience left a profound impact on photographer Chow and his partner, economist Huiyi Lin. For the past 13 years, they have dedicated themselves to exploring what it means to be economically disadvantaged.

Spanning more than 36 countries and territories, *The Poverty Line* documents the quantity and quality of food available to people living at the poverty line in countries ranging from Ethiopia to Turkey to the United Kingdom. "We realized that this project means something very different when it was placed in geographies around the world where people had different experiences about poverty, about food security," Chow has said. Lin adds, "Food, which is a basic necessity, is also how we connect with the world around us. And that daily need for food, without which we wouldn't be able to continue physically, has also become a daily pleasure. It is a basic human right.



Agosto Machado. *Shrine (White)*. 2022. Mixed-media installation, with jewelry, pins, and textiles; plastic, metal, glass, and papier-mâché objects; photographs, postcards, paper mask, protest sign, memorial-service cards and programs, and newspaper and magazine clippings; and original artworks by Scott Covert, Ken Angel Davis with CAConrad, and Gene Fedorko with Stephen Tashjian (Tabboo!), 91 1/2 × 36 × 10" (232.4 × 91.4 × 25.4 cm). Acquired through the generosity of Scott Lorinsky. © 2024 Agosto Machado. Courtesy of the artist

Agosto Machado is an artist who participated in the Stonewall uprising for LGBTQ rights. Over five decades, he amassed a large collection of art and ephemera from the city's counterculture. At the height of the AIDS crisis in the 1980s, he became a caretaker and activist. He assembles shrines memorializing losses he has experienced from a large personal collection of art and ephemera from the city's counterculture.

Shrine (White) is a tribute to a lost generation of people who died from AIDS, and includes everything from protest signs to funeral notices and intimate snapshots. "Throughout history in so many different cultures, as long as your name or your memory is remembered, you live," Machado explains. "And so a shrine can help you celebrate and commemorate all the people in your life that somehow changed you."

Mark as completed

Like Dislike Report an issue